state continued and all those who were found to have been derelict in their duties during Timur's long absences were hanged by the feet or beheaded.

Despite the opulence of the court described by Ruy González in 1404, Timur's beginnings, in 1336, were rather more pedestrian. He was born an ethnic Turk from a nomadic tribe in present-day Uzbekistan, in a region which was slowly crumbling under the weight of its earlier glory as the empire created by the great Mongolian ruler Chenghiz Khan fragmented into small, warring principalities. But Timur was a warlord of genius—charismatic, relentless, and violent. Pragmatic about not being a descendant of Chenghiz Khan himself, Timur married Chingizid women and always referred to himself and his dynasty as guregen or gurkani (in-laws) in a suitably deferential acknowledgement of the power of the Great Mongol. Timur was careful never to style himself as anything grander than amir, or beg, and never claimed for himself the exalted title of khan.* There was, however, nothing submissive about Timur's ambitions and, using a combination of military brilliance, the threat of extreme violence, and the willingness to convert enemies into allies, Timur set out from his capital of Samarkand in 1370 to conquer as much of the known world as he possibly could. By 1404, when he returned to Samarkand, Timur had sacked Baghdad and Delhi, marched up to Moscow, overrun Tiflis, Aleppo, and Damascus, and had accepted offers of submission from the Sultan of Egypt and the co-emperor of the Byzantine Empire, and was even contemplating the conquest of China.

Timur was pragmatic in claiming symbols of legitimacy from all sources that were available to him since his conquered peoples included a wide range of cultures from Persianized Turks to urban Sunni Muslims. For Timur, Chenghiz Khan's yassa laws that regulated the public and martial life of nomadic warriors were as binding as the charisma of the vibrant new religion—Islam. The sharia* of Islam was never as inflexible for Timur and his descendants, the Timurids, as it was for orthodox Muslims, and they found novel and accommodating ways to adjust to the needs of a heterogeneous group of subjects. Timur reached out to the legitimacy of the Sufis and adopted for himself an obscure pre-Islamic Persian title with supernatural implications—Sahib Qiran, Lord of the Auspicious Conjunction. Though meaningless to a modern reader, a Lord of Conjunction was a potent and sacred symbol of power in the medieval ages. It was given to a person whose sway over the material and divine world